

90-Day Federal Contracting Self-Study Plan

Focus: SBA 8(a) Program · FAR Part 19 · NCMA CFCM Certification

OVERVIEW

Four pillars across 13 weeks:

- **Business Posturing** — Entity setup, SAM, NAICS, socioeconomic certifications
 - **Fiscal Posturing** — Financial readiness, bonding, accounting systems, DCAA
 - **Contract Posturing** — FAR fluency, proposal writing, source selection, subcontracting
 - **Certification Path** — NCMA CFCM exam preparation
-

PHASE 1: FOUNDATION (Weeks 1–3)

Theme: Business Posturing & Federal Ecosystem

Week 1 — The Federal Contracting Ecosystem

Study:

- SBA.gov: 8(a) Business Development Program overview
- FAR Part 19.000–19.203 (Scope, Definitions, Policies, Relationship Among Programs)
- DAU SBP-1010: Introduction to Small Business Programs
- FedPropel.org and APEX Accelerators: Explore platform and local resources

Connection to 8(a):

FAR 19.8 is the regulatory backbone of the 8(a) program. DAU SBP-1010 explains how contracting officers interact with SBA to award 8(a) contracts — understanding both sides is essential.

✓ **Milestone:** Write a 1-page summary explaining the difference between a sole-source 8(a) award and a competitive 8(a) award, including the dollar thresholds (\$5.5M / \$8.5M manufacturing).

Week 2 — Business Posturing: Entity Setup & Registrations

Study:

- SBA: Basic requirements for federal contracting
- FAR 19.102: NAICS codes and size standards
- FAR 19.301: Representations and rerepresentations
- APEX Accelerators: Find your local accelerator; review pre-certification checklist

Connection to 8(a):

You cannot apply for 8(a) without an active SAM registration. NAICS code selection determines your size standard eligibility. FAR 19.301 governs how you represent your status in every offer.

✓ **Milestone:** Identify 3–5 NAICS codes relevant to your business. Confirm size standard for each. Draft a one-page capability statement.

Week 3 — 8(a) Eligibility & Application Requirements

Study:

- SBA 8(a) program: Eligibility criteria (13 CFR 124.101–124.112)
- FAR 19.802: Determining eligibility; FAR 19.816: 9-year term structure

- FedPropel.org: 8(a) application guidance
- McKinsey 7-Step PBA — Step 1: Apply 'define the problem' to your business development gap analysis

Connection to 8(a):

The McKinsey 7-Step PBA framework teaches structured problem definition before procurement. Applying Step 1 to your own business means honestly assessing whether 8(a) is the right vehicle for your stage of development.

✓ **Milestone:** Complete a self-assessment checklist against 8(a) eligibility criteria: social disadvantage narrative, economic disadvantage (net worth < \$850K), 51% ownership, management control. Identify gaps.

PHASE 2: FISCAL POSTURING (Weeks 4–6)

Theme: Financial Readiness for Federal Contracting

Week 4 — Accounting Systems & DCAA Compliance

Study:

- SBA: Governing rules and responsibilities
- FAR Part 31: Contract Cost Principles (allowable vs. unallowable costs)
- VA Acquisition Academy (acquisitionacademy.va.gov): Enroll in financial/cost accounting module
- McKinsey 7-Step PBA — Step 2: Identify accounting system alternatives

Connection to 8(a):

SBA requires 8(a) participants to demonstrate financial capability. DCAA-compliant accounting is required for cost-reimbursement contracts, common in 8(a) awards. The VA Acquisition Academy provides free federal acquisition training that mirrors what contracting officers learn.

✓ **Milestone:** Research whether your current accounting system meets DCAA adequacy standards. List the 10 elements of an adequate accounting system per DCAA SF 1408.

Week 5 — Bonding, Insurance & Financial Statements

Study:

- SBA: Surety bonds program
- FAR Part 28: Bonds and Insurance
- FAR 19.601–19.602: Certificates of Competency (COC)
- McKinsey 7-Step PBA — Step 3: Gather your financial documentation package

Connection to 8(a):

8(a) construction contracts require bonding capability. FAR 19.602 COC process protects small businesses from non-responsibility determinations — knowing this process is a competitive advantage.

✓ **Milestone:** Obtain a quote from an SBA-approved surety bond agent. Prepare a 1-page financial summary showing current ratio, working capital, and line of credit availability.

Week 6 — Subcontracting Plans & Teaming

Study:

- FAR 19.701–19.708: The Small Business Subcontracting Program (full subpart)
- FAR 19.809-2: Limitations on subcontracting for 8(a) — 50% rule for services
- SBA Mentor-Protégé Program overview
- McKinsey 7-Step PBA — Step 4: Analyze teaming partner capabilities vs. your gaps

Connection to 8(a):

The 50% limitation on subcontracting (FAR 19.809-2) is one of the most common compliance failures for 8(a) contractors. Mentor-protégé agreements allow 8(a) firms to team with large businesses while maintaining eligibility.

✓ **Milestone:** Draft a mock subcontracting plan outline for a hypothetical \$2M services contract, including goals for each small business category per FAR 19.704(a)(1).

PHASE 3: CONTRACT POSTURING (Weeks 7–10)

Theme: Winning and Performing Federal Contracts

Week 7 — Source Selection & Proposal Writing

Study:

- Army Source Selection Supplement (AS3): Study evaluation criteria, color/adjectival rating systems
- FAR Part 15.304–15.305: Evaluation factors and standards
- McKinsey 7-Step PBA — Step 5: Structure your technical approach section

Connection to 8(a):

Even sole-source 8(a) awards require negotiation (FAR 19.808-1). Competitive 8(a) awards above \$5.5M/\$8.5M use full source selection procedures. Understanding how evaluators score proposals using the AS3 framework directly improves win rates.

✓ **Milestone:** Using the AS3 color rating system, self-evaluate a past proposal or capability statement. Rewrite one section to achieve 'Blue/Outstanding.'

Week 8 — Performance-Based Acquisition & Statement of Work

Study:

- McKinsey 7-Step PBA — All 7 Steps: PWS/SOO development, performance standards, contract type selection
- VA Acquisition Academy: Enroll in Performance-Based Acquisition or Contract Writing course
- FAR Part 37.6: Performance-Based Acquisition

Connection to 8(a):

Federal agencies increasingly require performance-based contracts. 8(a) contractors who write strong PWS documents and propose measurable performance standards win more competitive 8(a) awards. The McKinsey 7-Step framework is the government's own methodology.

✓ **Milestone:** Write a 1-page Performance Work Statement (PWS) for a service your business provides, including 3 measurable performance standards with acceptable quality levels (AQLs).

Week 9 — Contract Types, Pricing & Negotiations

Study:

- FAR Part 16: Types of Contracts (FFP, CPFF, T&M, IDIQ, BPA)
- FAR Part 15.4: Contract Pricing; FAR 19.808: 8(a) contract negotiation
- McKinsey 7-Step PBA — Step 6: Select the right contract type
- VA Acquisition Academy: Contract pricing or negotiation module

Connection to 8(a):

FAR 19.808-1 governs sole-source 8(a) negotiations. The SBA must approve the contract before award. Understanding how contracting officers determine fair market price (FAR 19.807) is critical — if your price is too high, the agency can withdraw the 8(a) offering.

✓ **Milestone:** Build a price-to-win model: direct labor + fringe + overhead + G&A; + profit. Compare to GSA Schedule rates for similar services using GSA Advantage.

Week 10 — CMMC, Cybersecurity & Compliance

Study:

- CMMC 2.0 framework (dodcio.defense.gov/CMMC): Level 1 (17 practices), Level 2 (110 practices)
- FAR 52.204-21: Basic Safeguarding of Covered Contractor Information Systems
- DFARS 252.204-7012: Safeguarding Covered Defense Information
- AS3 supplement: Cybersecurity evaluation criteria in DoD source selections

Connection to 8(a):

DoD is the largest 8(a) contracting agency. CMMC compliance is now a prerequisite for DoD contracts. 8(a) firms pursuing DoD work must achieve CMMC Level 2 certification. Non-compliance disqualifies you from award regardless of 8(a) status.

✓ **Milestone:** Complete the CMMC Level 1 self-assessment (17 practices). Document your current SPRS score. Identify gaps.

PHASE 4: CERTIFICATION PATH (Weeks 11–13)

Theme: NCMA CFCM Exam Preparation

Week 11 — CFCM Body of Knowledge: FAR Mastery

Study:

- NCMA CFCM: 100 questions, 2 hours, ~70% passing; requires Bachelor's + 24 months experience
- CMBOK 6th Edition: Review the competency framework
- FAR Parts 1–4 and 13–15 (General, Simplified Acquisition, Sealed Bidding, Negotiation)
- VA Acquisition Academy: CFCM-aligned courses (contracting fundamentals, ethics)

Connection to 8(a):

The CFCM exam tests FAR knowledge from the contracting officer's perspective. Understanding how COs evaluate 8(a) offers, negotiate prices, and administer contracts makes you a more credible 8(a) contractor and stronger proposal writer.

✓ **Milestone:** Take a CFCM practice exam. Score your baseline. Target domains below 70% for focused review in Week 12.

Week 12 — CFCM Exam Prep: Contract Administration & Closeout

Study:

- FAR Parts 42–49: Contract Administration, Quality Assurance, Terminations
- FAR 19.812: 8(a) contract administration; FAR 19.815: Follow-on contract release requirements
- DAU SBP-1010 (revisit): Post-award small business compliance monitoring
- AS3 supplement: CPARS contractor performance assessment reporting

Connection to 8(a):

FAR 19.812 and 19.815 govern what happens after an 8(a) contract is awarded — including the critical rule that follow-on requirements must stay in the 8(a) program unless SBA releases them. CPARS ratings directly affect future award eligibility.

✓ **Milestone:** Write a 500-word explanation of the 8(a) contract administration lifecycle from award through closeout, citing specific FAR sections.

Week 13 — Integration, Review & Competency Demonstration

Study:

- Review all milestones from Weeks 1–12
- Complete second CFCM practice exam — target 75%+
- FedPropel.org: Review resources on 8(a) graduation and post-8(a) strategy
- APEX Accelerators: Schedule a one-on-one counseling session to review 8(a) application readiness

Connection to 8(a):

This capstone week consolidates all four pillars into a demonstrable competency portfolio. Scheduling your CFCM exam within 30 days creates accountability and a concrete credential goal.

✓ **Milestone:** Produce a Federal Contracting Competency Portfolio (8 items: eligibility assessment, NAICS analysis, DCAA gap analysis, mock subcontracting plan, PWS sample, price-to-win model, CMMC score, CFCM practice exam ≥75%). Schedule CFCM exam.

MEASURABLE MILESTONES SUMMARY

Week	Milestone	Competency Demonstrated
1	Sole-source vs. competitive 8(a) summary	FAR 19.8 fluency
2	NAICS analysis + capability statement	Business posturing
3	8(a) eligibility self-assessment	Certification readiness
4	DCAA accounting system gap analysis	Fiscal posturing
5	Surety bond quote + financial summary	Financial readiness
6	Mock subcontracting plan	FAR 19.7 compliance
7	AS3 self-evaluation of proposal	Source selection literacy
8	PWS with 3 performance standards	PBA competency
9	Price-to-win model	Pricing/negotiation
10	CMMC Level 1 self-assessment	Cybersecurity compliance
11	CFCM baseline practice exam	Certification readiness
12	8(a) lifecycle narrative (FAR-cited)	Contract administration
13	Full competency portfolio + CFCM ≥75%	All four pillars

KEY RESOURCE QUICK REFERENCE

Resource	URL	Primary Use
SBA 8(a) Program	sba.gov/.../8a-business-development-program	Eligibility, application
FAR Part 19	acquisition.gov/far/part-19	Regulatory foundation
NCMA CFCM	ncmahq.org/Web/Certification/CFCM.aspx	Certification path
FedPropel	fedpropel.org	8(a) strategy resources
APEX Accelerators	apexaccelerators.org	Local counseling
McKinsey 7-Step PBA	webarchive.library.unt.edu (UNT archive)	Proposal/PWS writing

VA Acquisition Academy	acquisitionacademy.va.gov	Free federal training
DAU SBP-1010	dau.edu	Small business program training
Army AS3	acquisition.gov/node/63332	Source selection literacy
CMMC	dodcio.defense.gov/CMMC	DoD cybersecurity compliance

Start today: Register at SAM.gov if not already active, bookmark all 10 resources above, and complete Week 1's milestone by end of day Friday.